



Finding Fido or Finding You?

AI, Surveillance & the Ring Super Bowl Ad

AI Literacy • Digital Citizenship • Privacy

Before We Watch

Think about it:

Does your family have a Ring doorbell or security camera at home?

How many cameras do you think you walk past on a normal day?

Quick Poll:

If your dog went missing, would you want every camera in your neighborhood scanning for it? Why or why not?



Let's Watch the Ad

Ring • "Be a Hero in Your Neighborhood" • Super Bowl LX (2026)



Watch for: What emotions does Ring want you to feel?

Search YouTube: "Ring Search Party Super Bowl 2026" — 30 seconds



Your First Reaction



What did you think? Heartwarming or creepy?

1

What emotions were you feeling while watching?

2

What is the ad actually showing you about the technology?

3

Did anything make you uncomfortable? If so, what?

How "Search Party" Actually Works

1

Dog owner uploads a photo to the Ring app

2

AI scans nearby outdoor Ring cameras for visual matches (breed, size, fur, markings)

3

If a match is found, the camera owner is notified

4

Camera owner decides whether to share the clip



KEY DETAIL: Search Party is ON by default. You have to opt OUT.

By the Numbers

20M

Ring devices in
American homes

125M

Super Bowl
viewers

~ 1/day

Dogs found
via Search Party

0.03%

Of lost dog reports
filed to Ring annually

Discussion: Ring spent \$8–10 million on a 30-second ad to tell 125 million people their cameras now scan neighborhoods using AI. What does that tell you about their goals?



What Could Go Wrong?

Before I show you what actually happened, let's think about this...

If AI can scan a neighborhood for a specific dog...
what else could it scan for?

Ring already has "Familiar Faces" — facial recognition
for people. How far is the leap from dogs to humans?

The feature is ON by default. What about the people
who walk past Ring cameras but don't own one?



Turn & talk with a partner for 2 minutes



So What Actually Happened?

One of the biggest ad backlashes in Super Bowl history.

The Internet Reacted

*"They don't even try to hide their dystopian plans.
They advertise them."*

— YouTube commenter on the Ring ad

*"This is how Batman found The Joker in The Dark Knight
and I don't like it."*

— @KevOnStage on X

*"Ring's Super Bowl advert this year uses dogs to
manufacture consent for mass surveillance."*

— WeRateDogs (nearly 20M followers)

Bipartisan backlash: Senator Ed Markey (D) AND GOP strategist Brady Smith both condemned it.



Watch: The Backlash

Option A

WeRateDogs Response

Matt Nelson breaks down how Ring uses dogs to normalize surveillance

Search: "WeRateDogs Ring" on Bluesky/YouTube
~3 min • 300K+ YouTube, 1.5M+ Instagram

Option B

Wyze Parody Ad

A competitor mocks Ring with fake 5-star reviews from the CIA, FBI, & ICE

Search: "Wyze Ring parody" on X/TikTok
~70 sec • Hilarious & informative



Teacher: Preview these before class and pick the best one (or show both!)



WeRateDogs superbowl response - facts to consider



Real-World Consequences



Feb 9

Super Bowl ad airs during the third quarter



Feb 10-11

Social media erupts — "creepy," "dystopian," "Orwellian"



Feb 11

WeRateDogs video goes viral (millions of views)



Feb 12

Ring cancels partnership with Flock Safety (surveillance firm)



Feb 12+

People film themselves ripping cameras off walls (3.2M+ views)

The Bigger Picture

This wasn't just about one ad. Ring has a history.

Familiar Faces

Ring already has facial recognition that identifies specific people approaching your door

Flock Safety

Partnered with a firm that makes license plate readers used by 5,000+ police departments

Community Requests

Law enforcement can request footage from Ring users during investigations — opt-out by default

Data Sharing

Reports show Flock data has been shared with ICE and federal agencies despite local restrictions



Key Concept: Function Creep

Function Creep

When technology built for one purpose gradually gets used for something else — often without the user realizing or consenting.

Examples:

→ GPS in phones: built for navigation → now used for targeted ads and tracking

→ Social media "likes": built for fun → now used to profile your personality for advertisers

→ Ring cameras: built for home security → now scanning for dogs → what's next?

"That power may be applied to puppies today, but where else might it be applied?"

Searches for people wearing t-shirts with certain political messages?"

— Jay Stanley, ACLU Senior Policy Analyst



"Deleted" Doesn't Mean Gone



The Nancy Guthrie Case & What "Delete" Really Means

Supplemental slides for the Ring / AI Surveillance lesson

What Happened?

One week before the Ring Super Bowl ad aired...

WHO

Nancy Guthrie (84), mother of TODAY show host Savannah Guthrie

WHAT

Kidnapped from her home in Tucson, AZ in the early hours of Feb. 1, 2026

THE CAMERA

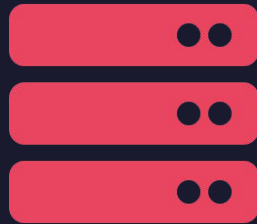
She had a Google Nest doorbell camera, but NO paid subscription

THE PROBLEM

The suspect disconnected the camera. Sheriff said no video was available.

THE TWIST

10 days later, the FBI recovered footage from Google's "backend systems"



Wait... How Did That Footage Even Exist?

1

Google's documentation says non-subscribers get only 3 hours of event video history

2

The camera was disconnected at 1:47 AM. She wasn't reported missing until the next morning — 9+ hours later.

3

The FBI recovered it 10 days later from "residual data in backend systems"



What Google's Policy Actually Says

What Users Are Told

- ✓ Without a subscription, you get up to 3 hours of event video previews
- ✓ Older footage is "deleted" when it expires
- ✓ You can "access, review, and delete this footage at any time"
- ✓ Camera only sends video when you've turned it on or enabled a feature

What Actually Happened

- ✗ Video was recovered 10 DAYS later, not 3 hours
- ✗ FBI extracted it from "residual data" on Google's servers
- ✗ Google cooperated and used engineers to excavate the data
- ✗ Data that was "deleted" still existed in backend systems

Buried in Google's privacy policy: "Some models of our cameras support recording video footage while offline... you may not see a visual indicator when your camera is sending the video footage to our servers."



Key Concept: "Delete" Is a Polite Fiction

How digital deletion actually works:

When you "delete" a file, the system just stops paying attention to it. The data remains on the server until something new overwrites that exact storage space. This can take days, weeks, or even months.

What the Experts Said:

"There's kind of this old saying that data is never deleted, it's just renamed."

Patrick Jackson, former NSA researcher & CTO of Disconnect

"The data wouldn't be available to users who didn't pay. The video for non-subscribers would be marked for deletion, but the actual files might not be deleted for days."

Alex Stamos, cybersecurity expert (to CBS News)

"We were able to go into their systems and actually excavate material that people would think would normally be deleted."

FBI Director Kash Patel (to Fox News)

The Privacy Paradox

Both of these statements can be true at the same time.

This Data Helped

- ✓ Gave FBI its first image of the suspect
- ✓ Generated 4,000+ tips in 24 hours
- ✓ Neighbor camera footage helped build a timeline of events
- ✓ Ring's Neighbors App was used to collect footage within 2 miles

This Is Alarming

- ✗ Google had video it told users didn't exist
- ✗ "Deleted" data was still sitting on their servers 10 days later
- ✗ Nancy Guthrie never chose to have this data stored
- ✗ If the FBI can get it, who else could — with a different warrant or a data breach?

"We should absolutely be alarmed over the privacy implications." — Michelle Dahl, Surveillance Technology Oversight Project



Same Week, Same Debate

Both of these events happened within days of each other in February 2026.

Feb 1

GUTHRIE

Nancy Guthrie kidnapped. Nest camera disconnected.

Feb 9

RING

Ring's Super Bowl ad airs. Public backlash begins.

Feb 10

GUTHRIE

FBI releases Nest footage from "backend systems." Privacy debate explodes.

Feb 12

RING

Ring cancels Flock Safety partnership. Investigators ask neighbors for doorbell footage.

The irony: The same camera network people were protesting after the Ring ad was being used to search for a kidnapped grandmother the very same week.



Discussion: The Hardest Question

1

Google had video that, according to their own policies, shouldn't have existed. Is that a good thing because it helped the investigation — or a bad thing because it means "delete" is a lie?

2

If you had a Nest camera with no subscription, would you want Google to secretly keep your footage just in case law enforcement might need it someday?

3

The Ring Neighbors App asked residents within 2 miles to share footage. That's the same community surveillance network from the Super Bowl ad. Does the Guthrie case change how you feel about it?

Sources — Guthrie Case & Privacy

NBC News	"Investigators wrangled video from Guthrie's Nest camera out of 'backend systems'"
NPR	"How the FBI might have gotten inaccessible camera footage"
CBS News	"Cybersecurity experts explain how surveillance footage was recovered"
Fortune / AP	"Google Nest still had the tape" — privacy policy analysis
Android Authority	"FBI recovers Nest Cam footage without a subscription, raising privacy concerns"
9News Denver	"FBI recovery of 'residual data' raises privacy concerns on doorbell cameras"
Tom's Guide	"How did the FBI get Guthrie's footage — and what does it mean for your privacy?"
Security Boulevard	"The FBI Recovered 'Deleted' Nest Cam Footage — Here's Why Every CISO Should Panic"
Google Nest	safety.google/nest — Security & Privacy Commitments page
Good Morning America	"Safety and privacy for home security cameras: What homeowners should know"

Case status as of Feb 25, 2026: Nancy Guthrie has not been found. \$1M family reward offered. Investigation ongoing.



The Privacy Debate (back to Ring)

Ring Says...

- ✓ It's voluntary — camera owners choose to share
- ✓ Only scans for dogs, not human biometrics
- ✓ It reunites families with lost pets
- ✓ Users control their footage
- ✓ Community Requests are transparent

Critics Say...

- ✗ Opt-OUT means most people never turn it off
- ✗ People walking by didn't consent to being filmed
- ✗ The same AI could easily scan for humans
- ✗ Ring has Familiar Faces (facial recognition) already
- ✗ History of sharing data with law enforcement

Opt-In vs. Opt-Out

This is one of the most important concepts in privacy design.

OPT-IN

You have to actively turn it ON.

Only people who want it get it.

Fewer users, but informed consent.

OPT-OUT

It's ON by default. You have to find
the setting and turn it OFF.

More users, but many don't even know.



Discussion: Why do you think Ring chose opt-out instead of opt-in?

Who benefits from that choice? Who is harmed?

Why a Lost Puppy?

Ring chose the most emotionally manipulative framing possible.

Manufacturing Consent

Using emotional stories (lost dogs, scared children, tearful reunions) to get people to accept something they might otherwise reject — like a neighborhood-wide AI surveillance network.

Think About It:

→ Would you feel the same if the ad showed cameras tracking a person?

→ What if it showed police requesting footage from your camera?

→ What if the ad honestly said: "AI will scan your neighborhood 24/7"?



Your Turn: Write the Warning Label

Imagine the government required a "Digital Privacy Label" on every smart device — like a nutrition label, but for your data.

Write a privacy warning label for Ring's Search Party that includes:

1. What data is collected and by whom
2. Who can access it (and who might access it in the future)
3. What risks exist that Ring doesn't mention in the ad
4. **One sentence connecting this to your own life**



Were Watching! (Not just your pets!)

- ✓ Can identify people
- ✓ flock data has been shared with ICE
- ✓ partnered with a firm that reads license plate numbers

What Did We Learn?

AI is not just chatbots

It's in cameras, doorbells, and devices making decisions about what they see — all around you, every day.

Function creep is real

Technology built for one thing often gets used for another. The infrastructure for finding dogs IS the infrastructure for finding people.

Design choices = power

Opt-in vs. opt-out isn't just a setting — it's a decision about who has power over your data.

Emotions aren't arguments

Just because an ad makes you feel something doesn't mean the technology behind it is safe or ethical.

Sources & Video Links

Ring Super Bowl Ad

Search YouTube: "Ring Search Party Be a Hero" (30 sec)

WeRateDogs Response

Search Bluesky/YouTube: "WeRateDogs Ring" (~3 min)

Wyze Parody Ad

Search X/TikTok: "Wyze Ring parody" @WyzeCam (~70 sec)

EFF Blog Post

eff.org — "Ring's Super Bowl Ad"

USA Today Coverage

"Why are people disconnecting Ring cameras?"

GeekWire Explainer

"What Ring's Search Party actually does"

Variety

"Ring Cancels Flock Partnership After Backlash"

The Ringer

"How a Cute Dog in a Super Bowl Ad Revealed a Surveillance Crisis"